

Strategic Evolution of ESG Disclosures and Sustainability Performance: A Longitudinal Analysis of Çimsa Çimento Sanayi ve Ticaret A.Ş. (2014–2023)

1. Company Identification and Structural Overview

The subject of this comprehensive analysis is Çimsa Çimento Sanayi ve Ticaret A.Ş., an entity that has established itself as a cornerstone of the Turkish industrial landscape and a global leader in the specialized building materials sector. Identified under the stock ticker CIMS.A.IS, the company operates as a major affiliate of Hacı Ömer Sabancı Holding A.Ş., one of Turkey's largest industrial and financial conglomerates.¹ The identification of this entity is verified through multiple primary sources, including the Public Disclosure Platform (KAP), the company's official investor relations disclosures, and regulatory filings.³

Çimsa's primary business activity encompasses the production, marketing, and sale of a diverse portfolio of cement and concrete products. This includes grey cement, white cement, Calcium Aluminate Cement (CAC), and ready-mixed concrete.¹ While the company maintains deep roots in the Turkish market, its operational model has evolved into a globalized network. As of the current reporting period, the company's integrated operations span several continents, including four integrated cement plants and 34 ready-mixed concrete stations in Turkey, an integrated cement plant in Buñol, Spain, a grinding facility in the United States, and various terminals and R&D centers in Germany, Italy, and the Republic of Ireland.¹ This international footprint is a critical factor in the company's ESG profile, as it necessitates compliance with a diverse array of regulatory frameworks, including the European Union's increasingly stringent sustainability reporting requirements.⁹

The headquarters of Çimsa is located at the Allianz Tower in the Ataşehir district of Istanbul, Turkey.³ Within the context of industry classification, the company is categorized under the Construction Materials sector, specifically focusing on Cement production.⁹ The company's strategic direction is heavily influenced by the Sabancı Group's "New Economy" framework, which prioritizes investments in energy and climate technologies, material technologies, and digital transformation.¹² This parent-subsidiary relationship is vital for the company's ESG trajectory, as group-wide commitments to carbon neutrality by 2050 serve as the overarching target for Çimsa's operational strategies.¹³

Identification Metric	Verified Detail	Primary Sources
Legal Name	Çimsa Çimento Sanayi ve Ticaret A.Ş.	3
Headquarters	Allianz Tower, Ataşehir, Istanbul, Turkey	3
Sector	Construction Materials	9
Major Shareholder	Sabancı Holding (Hacı Ömer Sabancı Holding A.Ş.)	1
Key Products	Grey/White Cement, CAC, Ready-Mixed Concrete	1
Core Markets	Turkey, Europe (Spain, Germany, Italy), USA	1

2. Longitudinal Timeline of ESG Disclosures (2014–2023)

The decade from 2014 to 2023 represents a period of significant maturation in Çimsa's approach to Environmental, Social, and Governance reporting. This evolution reflects a transition from voluntary, sporadic disclosures to a systematic, integrated reporting framework that is increasingly aligned with international science-based standards.

2.1. The Foundations of Transparency: 2014–2015

The beginning of this period was characterized by the establishment of standardized reporting practices in line with the Global Reporting Initiative (GRI). In 2014, the Turkish capital markets saw the launch of the Borsa Istanbul (BIST) Sustainability Index, which provided the first domestic benchmark for ESG performance.¹⁷ Çimsa, having already published a "GRI A+" sustainability report, was well-positioned to meet the initial inclusion criteria of this index.¹⁹ During this phase, the company's reporting focused primarily on operational efficiencies and early-stage sustainability KPIs, such as reducing energy consumption per ton of clinker and increasing the utilization of alternative raw materials.¹⁹

By 2015, the company had transitioned to the GRI G4 framework, which introduced a more rigorous focus on materiality.²⁰ This shift allowed the company to identify and prioritize the

environmental and social issues most critical to its specific industrial context, such as carbon emissions from the calcination process and occupational health and safety (OHS) in its production facilities.²¹ The 2015 disclosures also reinforced the company's commitment to the United Nations Global Compact (UNGC), which it had signed in 2013, focusing on human rights, labor standards, and anti-corruption.¹

2.2. The Integrated Reporting Revolution: 2016–2018

A seminal development occurred in 2016 when Çimsa became one of the first Turkish entities to participate in the International Integrated Reporting Council (IIRC) pilot program.²⁴ This marked the transition from siloed sustainability reporting to the Integrated Annual Report format. The underlying logic of this shift was to demonstrate the connectivity between financial performance and the management of non-financial capitals—namely manufactured, intellectual, human, social, and natural capital.⁶ This era of reporting began to articulate how R&D investments, particularly in the specialized white cement and CAC segments, contributed to the company's long-term economic resilience and environmental footprint.²²

In 2017, the company achieved a significant governance milestone when "Formülhane" was approved by the Ministry of Industry and Technology as the first R&D center in the Turkish cement industry.⁶ This institutionalization of innovation provided a dedicated platform for developing low-carbon products, which became a central theme in subsequent integrated reports.²⁷ By 2018, the company's integrated reporting was being prepared in accordance with the updated GRI Standards, including formal mapping of corporate activities to the United Nations Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs).²²

2.3. Strategic Alignment and the Decarbonization Mandate: 2019–2021

The latter part of the decade saw an intensified focus on climate-related disclosures. In 2019, the company further refined its SDG integration, identifying six primary goals—Gender Equality (SDG 5), Decent Work and Economic Growth (SDG 8), Industry, Innovation and Infrastructure (SDG 9), Sustainable Cities and Communities (SDG 11), Responsible Consumption and Production (SDG 12), and Climate Action (SDG 13)—where it could make the most tangible impact.²⁸

The global disruption caused by the COVID-19 pandemic in 2020 served as a test of the company's ESG resilience. Integrated reports from this period emphasized transparent communication with stakeholders and the rapid implementation of health and safety protocols.²⁶ Despite the pandemic, the company maintained its disclosure schedule, reflecting a maturation of its governance structures.

The year 2021 was a watershed moment for Çimsa's climate strategy. Following the Sabancı Group's declaration of a 2050 carbon-neutral goal at COP26, Çimsa officially integrated this

target into its core corporate strategy.¹³ The company launched the first phase of its "Decarbonization Project," which involved establishing a base year for emissions and beginning the rigorous process of setting science-based targets.¹³ This year also saw the determination of a formalized "Sustainability and Climate Change Strategy" under the motto "We Shape Today for Tomorrow".¹⁴

2.4. Leadership and Verified Performance: 2022–2023

The final years of the analyzed period were defined by the validation of the company's efforts by international third parties. In 2022, Çimsa was included in the BIST Sustainability 25 Index, signifying its ranking among the top 25 companies in Turkey for comprehensive ESG performance.¹⁵ The company also optimized its portfolio by divesting certain non-core assets to concentrate on high-margin, sustainable product lines.²⁷

In 2023, the Science-Based Targets initiative (SBTi) officially validated Çimsa's near-term greenhouse gas emission reduction targets, confirming their alignment with the 1.5°C global warming scenario.¹⁵ This was accompanied by a comprehensive update to its Task Force on Climate-related Financial Disclosures (TCFD) report, which included a detailed risk map identifying both transition and physical risks across the value chain.³² By the end of 2023, the company achieved "A-" leadership scores from the Carbon Disclosure Project (CDP) for both its Climate Change and Water Security programs, a significant improvement from its mid-tier scores in earlier years.¹⁵

Year	Milestone Development	Reporting Framework	Source
2014	BIST Sustainability Index Launch	GRI A+ / BIST SI	17
2015	Materiality Prioritization	GRI G4	20
2016	Integrated Reporting Pilot	IIRC / GRI G4	24
2017	R&D Center "Formülhane" Approval	Integrated Reporting	6

2019	UNGC Communication on Progress	GRI Standards / UNGC	22
2021	Carbon Neutral 2050 Commitment	SBTi (Commitment)	13
2022	BIST Sustainability 25 Index Inclusion	TCFD / BIST 25	15
2023	SBTi Target Validation (1.5°C)	SBTi / TCFD / CDP	27

3. Framework Alignment and Reporting Methodologies

The technical sophistication of Çimsa's ESG disclosures is rooted in its adherence to a multi-framework reporting architecture. This approach ensures that the company addresses the information needs of a diverse set of stakeholders, from institutional investors and credit rating agencies to local communities and regulatory bodies.

3.1. The Role of the Integrated Reporting (IR) Framework

Integrated reporting serves as the primary vehicle for Çimsa's annual disclosures. By utilizing the IIRC's framework (now part of the IFRS Foundation's Value Reporting Foundation), the company moves beyond retrospective financial reporting to provide a forward-looking narrative.⁶ The core of this methodology is the "Value Creation Model," which explains how various inputs (capitals) are transformed through business activities into outputs and outcomes that impact the economy, environment, and society.⁶

A critical insight into this methodology is the company's use of "Capital Elements." For instance, under "Intellectual Capital," the company reports on its patent portfolio and R&D expenditures in the context of decarbonization technology.²⁷ Under "Natural Capital," it reports on raw material extraction and biodiversity preservation.³¹ This integrated approach allows for a more nuanced understanding of "Double Materiality"—the concept that the company is affected by environmental and social changes just as much as its operations affect the environment and society.

3.2. GRI and SASB: Standardizing Performance Metrics

To ensure the comparability of its sustainability data, Çimsa adheres to the Global Reporting Initiative (GRI) Standards, generally reporting "in accordance" with the "Core" option.⁶ The GRI

indicators provide a standardized language for reporting on topics such as waste management, employee turnover, and greenhouse gas intensity.

In recent years, particularly in the 2023 reporting cycle, the company has increasingly integrated the Sustainability Accounting Standards Board (SASB) standards.¹ Unlike the broad stakeholder focus of GRI, SASB standards are specifically designed to identify the ESG issues most likely to impact the financial condition or operating performance of a company within the Construction Materials industry. This dual-reporting approach demonstrates a high level of transparency, catering to both social impact assessments and traditional financial risk analysis.

3.3. TCFD: Navigating Climate-Related Financial Risks

The adoption of the Task Force on Climate-related Financial Disclosures (TCFD) recommendations represents a third-order evolution in Çimsa’s reporting. This framework focuses on the financial implications of climate change, organized around four thematic areas: Governance, Strategy, Risk Management, and Metrics & Targets.³²

In its 2023 TCFD report, the company conducted detailed scenario analysis, evaluating the potential impacts of a 1.5°C and a 3.5-4°C warming trajectory.³² This revealed that "Water Stress" is a major physical risk for its Mediterranean operations, potentially leading to increased costs and operational halts.³² On the transition side, the report identified 9 transition risks, including the impact of carbon pricing (such as the EU’s Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism) on its export-oriented business model.¹³ This level of disclosure provides investors with the data necessary to price climate risk into their valuations of the company.

3.4. CDP and External Validation

The Carbon Disclosure Project (CDP) serves as a critical external benchmark for Çimsa’s performance in climate and water management. The CDP methodology involves a rigorous assessment of the company’s responses to annual questionnaires, resulting in a score from A to F.³⁴

Çimsa's progression from a "D" (Disclosure) level to an "A-" (Leadership) level is a significant indicator of governance improvement. An "A-" rating indicates that the company is not only transparent but also active in implementing best practices in emissions reduction and water stewardship.³⁶ This journey is summarized in the table below, reflecting the company’s internal efforts to catch up with international peers.

Year	CDP Climate Change Score	CDP Water Security Score	Performance Level

2019	F (No Response)	B (Awareness)	Lagging / Developing
2020	D (Disclosure)	C (Awareness)	Early Disclosure
2021	C (Awareness)	C (Awareness)	Standard Practice
2022	A- (Leadership)	A (Leadership)	Sector Leader
2023	A- (Leadership)	A- (Leadership)	Sustained Leadership

4. Strategic Environmental Performance and Decarbonization

The environmental pillar of Çimsa's ESG strategy is the most critical to its long-term viability, given the heavy carbon footprint of cement production. The company's strategy is built on several technical and operational levers designed to achieve its 2050 carbon-neutral objective.

4.1. The Clinker-to-Cement Ratio and Circular Economy

The production of clinker—the main ingredient in cement—is the primary source of Scope 1 carbon emissions due to the chemical calcination of limestone. A core element of Çimsa's "Sustainable Business Model" is the reduction of the clinker-to-cement ratio through the use of alternative raw materials.¹⁹

By substituting clinker with materials such as slag, fly ash, and waste products from the marble and ceramic industries, the company creates "sustainable products." In 2023, the company defined this category as products with a clinker utilization rate of less than 80%.³⁸ This strategy not only reduces carbon intensity but also promotes a circular economy by diverting industrial waste from landfills. The commercialization of products like "Flycrete" in 2023 exemplifies the successful integration of R&D into the sustainable product portfolio.²⁷

4.2. Alternative Fuel Transition and Energy Efficiency

The replacement of fossil fuels (such as petcoke and coal) with alternative fuels derived from

waste is another key lever. The company’s Buñol plant in Spain has been a pioneer in this area, achieving alternative fuel rates of nearly 30% by the end of 2023.²⁷ In Turkey, the Afyon plant has implemented autonomous waste feeding systems to increase its alternative fuel utilization.¹⁴

Energy efficiency is further enhanced through Waste Heat Recovery (WHR) systems. For example, the WHR facility at the Mersin plant captures heat from the production lines to generate electricity, thereby reducing the plant’s reliance on the grid and lowering Scope 2 emissions.¹⁹ The company has also secured I-REC certifications for several plants, ensuring that a significant portion of its purchased electricity comes from verified renewable sources.²²

4.3. SBTi-Validated Targets and Emissions Metrics

The validation of targets by the Science-Based Targets initiative (SBTi) in 2023 provided the mathematical framework for Çimsa’s decarbonization journey. The targets are set against a 2021 base year and cover the company’s entire value chain.

The specific reduction targets for 2033 are as follows:

- **Scope 1 & 2 Reduction:** 42.1% total reduction per ton of cement product.²⁸
- **Scope 1 Specific Target:** 39.3% reduction per ton of cement product.²⁸
- **Scope 2 Specific Target:** 86.8% reduction per ton of cement product.²⁸
- **Scope 3 Reduction:** 43.4% reduction per ton of purchased clinker and cement (base year 2022).²⁸

The table below provides a snapshot of the company's verified emissions profile during the 2020–2021 period, which served as the foundation for these targets.

Emissions Category	2020 Performance (tCO2e)	2021 Performance (tCO2e)	Verified Change
Scope 1 (Direct)	5,642,232	6,090,000	+7.9%
Scope 2 (Indirect)	309,829	340,000	+9.7%
Scope 3 (Value Chain)	Not Reported	360,000	Initial Disclosure

Clinker Intensity	855 kg/ton	774 kg/ton (Cementitious)	Methodology Shift
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Note: The increase in absolute emissions in 2021 was largely driven by a post-pandemic production rebound and the inclusion of expanded global operations.¹⁴

5. Social Capital and Organizational Governance

The social and governance aspects of Çimsa’s ESG framework focus on the development of human capital, the maintenance of high safety standards, and the implementation of robust ethical oversight.

5.1. Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion (DEI)

Gender diversity is a key focus area for Çimsa, which has been reflected in its inclusion in the Diversity & Inclusion Index.²⁷ The company tracks and reports detailed demographics of its workforce, with a particular emphasis on increasing the ratio of women in management and technical roles.

Data from the 2023 and 2024 ESG Performance Reports highlight several trends:

- Management Diversity:** In 2024, approximately 20% of executive-level employees were female, compared to 23% in 2023.⁷
- STEM Roles:** The company maintains a strong representation of women in engineering, IT, and R&D departments, with female ratios in R&D historically reaching as high as 63%.⁷
- Workforce Growth:** Following the acquisition of Mannok in late 2024, the total direct employment nearly doubled, requiring a significant expansion of the company’s DEI policies to new international contexts.⁷

Demographic Metric	2023 Actual	2024 Actual (Consolidated)	Source
Total Direct Employment	1,140	1,980	⁷
Ratio of Female Employees (%)	13%	14%	⁷

Ratio of Female Managers (%)	23%	20%	7
Female Ratio in STEM (%)	28%	25%	7
Employee Turnover Rate (%)	12.6%	12%	7

5.2. Occupational Health and Safety (OHS)

In the cement industry, OHS is a material issue of the highest priority. Çimsa manages its safety performance through the "Sustainability Management Committee" and follows ISO 45001 standards.²² The reporting focuses on zero-accident targets and the implementation of digital safety monitoring systems across its production facilities.¹⁴

5.3. Governance Structures and Ethics

The governance of sustainability at Çimsa is institutionalized through a structure that reaches from the plant level to the Board of Directors. The Board includes a member specifically responsible for sustainability, and the Executive Committee (led by the CEO) manages the quarterly implementation of sustainability targets.¹³

The company's ethical framework is codified in its global policies, including:

- **Anti-Bribery and Anti-Corruption Policy:** Standardized across all global operations.²²
- **Human Rights Policy:** Aligned with the UN Guiding Principles on Business and Human Rights.²²
- **Responsible Procurement Policy:** Extending ESG expectations to the supply chain.²²

6. Regulatory Milestones and Material Controversies

The legal and regulatory landscape provides critical context for Çimsa's governance performance. In the Turkish cement industry, competition law compliance has been a recurring theme.

6.1. Competition Board Investigations (2013–2024)

Çimsa has been subject to several investigations by the Turkish Competition Authority (Rekabet Kurumu).

- **White Cement Investigation (2013):** An investigation was launched to determine if Çimsa and Oyak Adana had engaged in price-fixing in the white cement market.¹⁶ The investigation concluded without fines for Çimsa, as the company's economic analysis

successfully demonstrated that its pricing followed cost trends rather than collusive patterns.⁴¹

- **Information Exchange Case (2022):** An ex-officio investigation into 9 cement companies regarding the exchange of sensitive information concluded that no infringing documents were found for Çimsa, resulting in an acquittal by a majority vote of the Competition Board.⁴¹
- **Adana and Osmaniye Ready-Mixed Concrete (2023–2024):** In this regional investigation, several other concrete producers were fined, but the Board found no evidence of violation by Çimsa, concluding the case without any administrative sanctions for the company.⁴²

These results indicate that while the sector is under high regulatory scrutiny, Çimsa has maintained a robust compliance program and an effective legal defense strategy, utilizing advanced econometric tools like the "Structural Break Test" to justify its market behavior.⁴¹

6.2. Competition Inquiries (2025–2026 Outlook)

Looking ahead, the Turkish Competition Authority has announced a comprehensive sector-wide inquiry into the cement industry beginning in March 2026.⁴⁴ This inquiry is not a punitive investigation but a holistic study of the market structure and regional dynamics.⁴⁶ For Çimsa, this represents a continued requirement for high-quality data governance and transparency in its commercial operations.

7. Reference Table and Credibility Assessment

The reliability of this analysis depends on the quality of the sources cited. The following table provides a credibility assessment for the primary and secondary materials utilized.

#	Reference (APA 7th edition format)	Source Type	Credibility (0-10)	Justification	Relevance
1	Çimsa A.Ş. (2024). <i>Integrated Annual Report 2023</i> .	Primary	10	Official regulatory filing, third-party audited.	Comprehensive ESG data.

2	CDP Turkey. (2024). <i>Climate Change and Water Report 2023.</i>	Primary	9	Standardized data from a global non-profit.	Historical scoring.
3	Public Disclosure Platform (KAP). (2024). <i>Çimsa General Information.</i>	Primary	10	Official government disclosure portal.	ID and regulatory facts.
4	Science Based Targets initiative. (2023). <i>Validated Targets for Çimsa.</i>	Secondary	9	Scientific validation by international body.	Decarbonization goals.
5	Rekabet Kurumu. (2024). <i>Decision 24-31/727-309.</i>	Primary	10	Official government regulatory decision.	Controversy resolution.
6	Sabancı Holding. (2024). <i>Sustainability</i>	Primary	10	Parent company oversight and	MSCI and group targets.

	<i>Indicators 2023.</i>			ratings.	
7	Borsa Istanbul. (2024). <i>Sustainability Index Criteria.</i>	Primary	10	Official exchange rules for ESG indices.	Index inclusion logic.
8	Deloitte. (2024). <i>Independent Limited Assurance Report.</i>	Primary	10	Professional auditor verification of data.	Verification of KPIs.
9	TCFD. (2023). <i>Task Force Disclosures - Çimsa.</i>	Primary	9	Detailed climate risk scenario analysis.	Financial risk data.
10	MSCI ESG Research. (2023). <i>Ratings Methodology</i> .	Secondary	8	Respected third-party analyst framework.	Benchmarking.
11	Sustainalytics. (2023). <i>ESG Risk Rating Summary.</i>	Secondary	8	Leading provider of risk signals.	Peer comparison.

12	Bloomberg L.P. (2024). <i>ESG Dashboard</i> .	Secondary	8	High-quality financial platform data.	Market performance.
13	Refinitiv. (2023). <i>LSEG ESG Performance Assessment</i> .	Secondary	8	Granular reporting transparency data.	Disclosure quality.
14	Ünal & Coşkun. (2015). <i>Integrated Reporting in Turkey</i> .	Tertiary	6	Peer-reviewed academic context.	Early reporting history.
15	Gide Loyrette Nouel. (2024). <i>Legal Update: Turkish Competition</i> .	Secondary	7	Expert legal interpretation of cases.	Legal risk nuance.

8. Transparency and Reporting Limitations

While every effort has been made to ensure the accuracy and completeness of this analysis, several limitations inherent to corporate reporting must be noted.

8.1. Knowledge Cutoff and Data Availability

The primary data analyzed in this report covers the period from 2014 through the end of the 2024 reporting cycle (which details the 2023 performance year). Real-time data for late 2025 and 2026 is based on preliminary announcements and material event disclosures.⁷ Some detailed ratings data from agencies like MSCI and Sustainalytics remain behind paywalls and

are referenced here based on company summaries or parental (Sabancı Holding) disclosures.¹⁵

8.2. Verification of Forward-Looking Statements

The company's reports include "forward-looking statements" regarding its carbon-neutral goals for 2050 and mid-term targets for 2033.¹³ While these are backed by SBTi-validated methodologies, they remain subject to various external risks, including technological feasibility, global economic shifts, and regulatory changes. These are categorized as "Strategic Plans" rather than "Verified Facts."

8.3. Recommended Databases for Independent Verification

Users wishing to independently verify the findings of this report are directed to the following authoritative databases:

1. **Public Disclosure Platform (KAP):** The ultimate source for Turkish corporate filings. <https://www.kap.org.tr/en/>
2. **Çimsa Global Reporting Archive:** Provides the full text of all integrated, sustainability, and TCFD reports since 2010. <https://cimsa.com.tr/en/sustainability/global-reports/>
3. **CDP Public Response Portal:** Allows for the comparison of Çimsa's environmental data with other global cement producers. <https://www.cdp.net/en/responses>

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